CHAPTER TEN

Israel and the Jews as Prisms for Understanding Europe Today

Manfred Gerstenfeld

Prisms are valuable tools with which to observe society and focus on its specific aspects. With a rather modest effort, the use of such an analytical instrument can provide ways to understand a multitude of characteristics of a society or an institution. This will be illustrated by presenting examples of what four interrelated prisms can tell us—the Holocaust, the post-Holocaust era, the Jews, and Israel. Using the Holocaust as one prism, the essence of the German atrocities and of Allied attitudes can be understood. The post-Holocaust period exposed particular aspects of various postwar democratic governments. The Jews, as a group can provide a useful prism for gaining an understanding of the disorientation and degradation of contemporary societies. Finally, Israel as a prism reveals how much the "anti-racist" camp is actually riddled with antisemites.

THE HOLOCAUST AS A PRISM

The Holocaust and the various attitudes toward it can serve as an illustration of how easily complete falsehoods can be propagated. At many levels within the Arab and Muslim world, Holocaust denial is rampant. Yet this has not prevented the so-called *Naqba* (the defeat of the Arabs in the 1948 war they initiated against Israel) from being compared by the Palestinians with the Holocaust. This additional falsehood would make no sense if there had been no Holocaust.

Another example of how widespread the similar lies are within the Arab public domain has been addressed by the Belgian political scientist Jöel Kotek:

> Long before Sharon came to power, the theme of the Israeli as a Nazi appeared in Arab cartoons everywhere. According to them, all Zionists from Barak to Sharon, by way of Peres, drew their inspiration

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